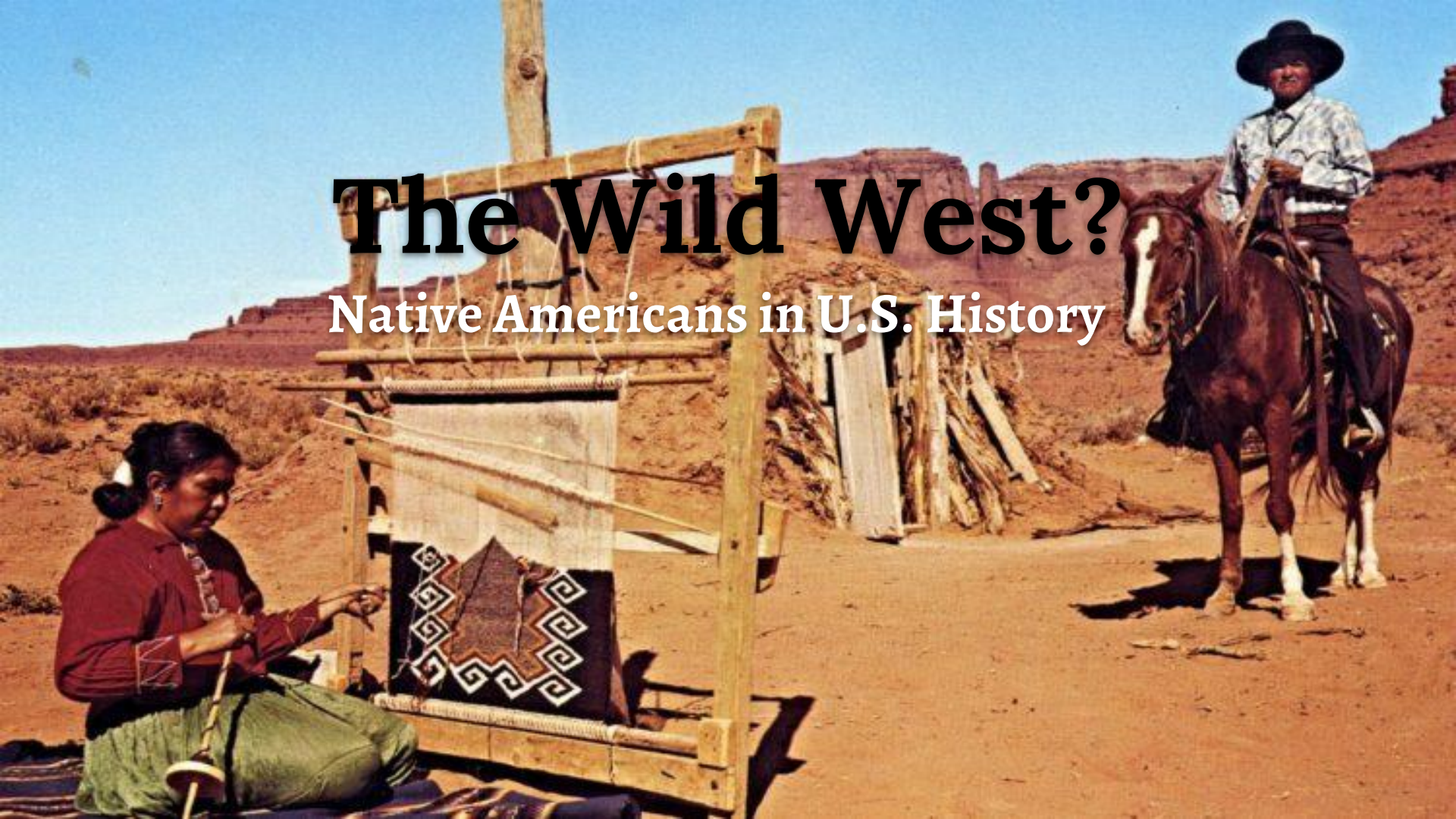


The Wild West?

Native Americans in U.S. History

A Note on Terms

- When working with historical documents, you may encounter racist, oppressive, or outdated language in the documents themselves or in the archival record.
- When we discuss these items, we will want to use terms that reflect the ways communities describe themselves today.

Suggested Topics

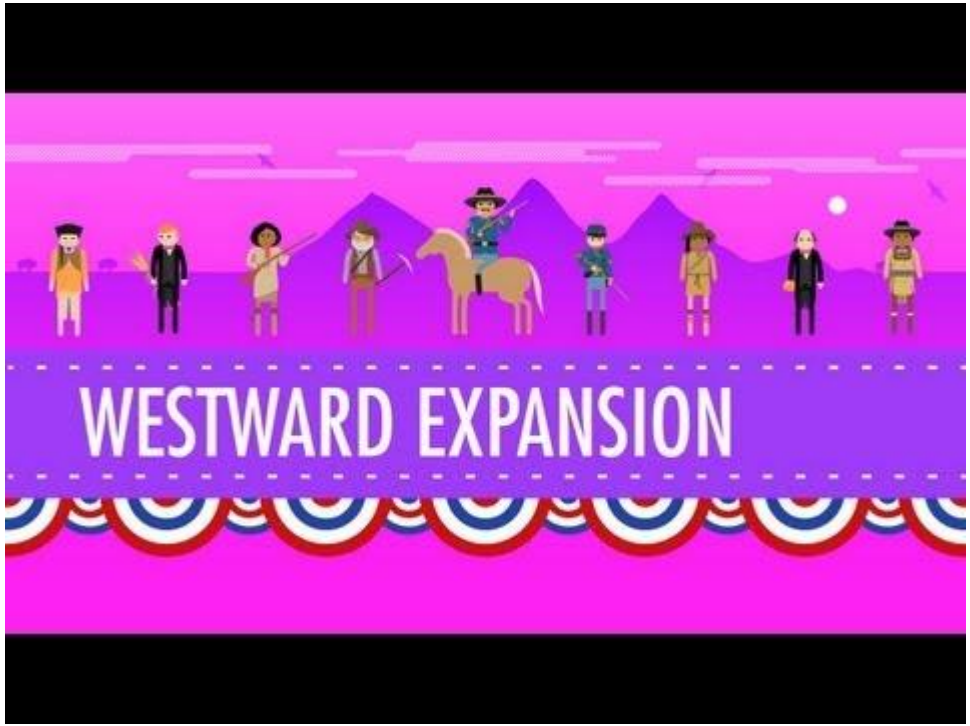
- The Market Revolution
- Westward Expansion
- Manifest Destiny
- Native People in the Southwest
- Indian Removal
- 19th Century



Discussion Questions

What is the significance of:

- Westward expansion
- Railroad
- Dawes Act
- Homestead Act
- Buffalo
- Boarding schools
- Civilize



Speech by Chief Joseph (1879)

“I cannot understand why so many chiefs are allowed to talk so many different ways, and promise so many different things. I have seen the Great Father Chief [President Hayes]; the Next Great Chief [Secretary of the Interior]; the Commissioner Chief; the Law Chief; and many other law chiefs [Congressmen] and they all say they are my friends, and that I shall have justice, but while all their mouths talk right I do not understand why nothing is done for my people. **I have heard talk and talk but nothing is done. Good words do not last long unless they amount to something. Words do not pay for my dead people. They do not pay for my country now overrun by white men. They do not protect my father's grave. They do not pay for my horses and cattle. Good words do not give me back my children. Good words will not make good the promise of your war chief, General Miles.** Good words will not give my people a home where they can live in peace and take care of themselves. I am tired of talk that comes to nothing. It makes my heart sick when I remember all the good words and all the broken promises. ...

I only ask of the Government to be treated as all other men are treated. If I cannot go to my own home, let me have a home in a country where my people will not die so fast. I would like to go to Bitter Root Valley. There my people would be happy; where they are now they are dying. Three have died since I left my camp to come to Washington.

When I think of our condition, my heart is heavy. I see men of my own race treated as outlaws and driven from country to country, or shot down like animals.”



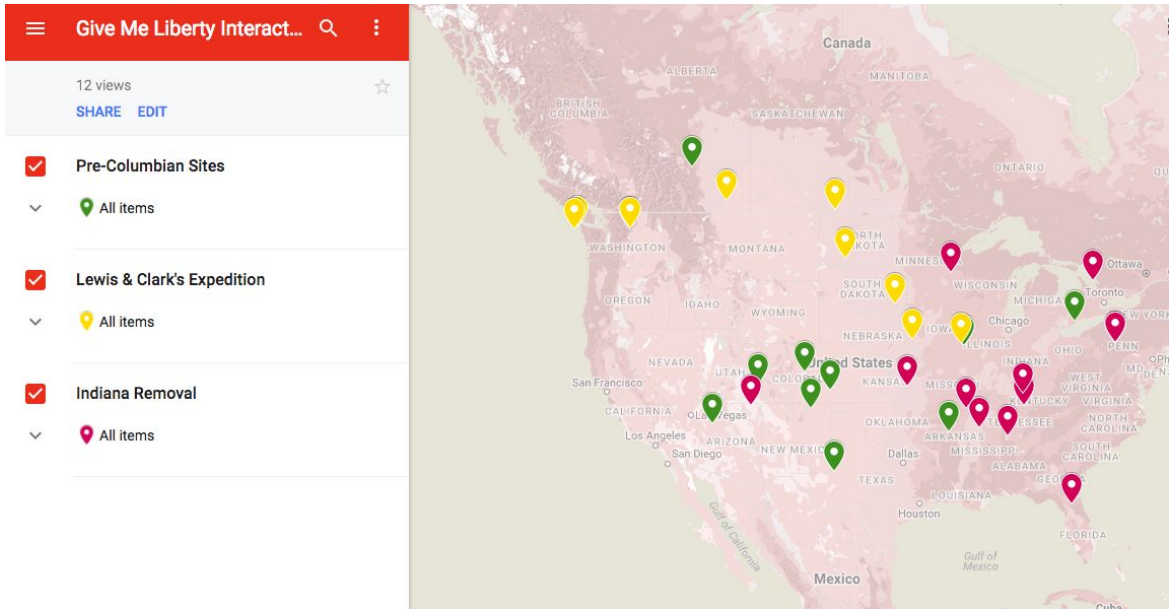
High School Assignment: In-Class Presentation

1.Select theme from *Give Me Liberty!* Map

2. Slide 1- Choose Postcard from Woven Into History. Describe it briefly (who is in it, how is it described, how is it relevant to the discussion)

3. Slide 2/3- Outline of main terms with definitions. (5 W's- who, what, why, when, where)

4. Present to Class



College Assignment: In-Class Presentation

1. Select Primary source reading

- President Jackson's speech on Indian Removal (1830)
- Homestead Act (1862)
- Dawes Act (1887)

2. Create Presentation for class to include

- One image/postcard from Woven Into History
- Historical context of image including relevance to primary source
- Main themes of primary source document & significance (5 W's- Who, what, why, when, where)

EXAMPLE

Slide 1

Title: “Toka-Wicakin- Takes Enemy in War Paint" - 1901

Photographer: W M. H. Rau or William Herman Rau (January 19, 1855 – November 19, 1920)

Most of his photographs are of landscape, however he does include some of Chiefs “in costume” at the World’s Fair. This photo was likely taken at the Pan American Exposition in Buffalo, NY.



Slide 2

This photograph was taken at the turn of the century after a series of incredibly tragic interactions Indigenous people. While being persecuted, imaginations of “savagery” and “indianness” were celebrated in contrast to American civility.

- Cherokee Nation v. Georgia- 5 W’s
- Worcester v. Georgia -5 W’s
- Treaty of New Echota -5 W’s

